Philosophy 25A: Ancient Philosophy

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24 September 2023

Prompt 3

Socrates' Moral Dilemma of Obedience to the State

In his dialogue with Crito, Socrates acknowledges that states can create unjust laws, but it is a citizen's duty to obey the laws despite their unjustness. I seek to reconstruct Socrates' argument through the premises that support it, and then elaborate further on what I suppose to be the strongest objection to Socrates' claim. First, I will explain what Socrates deems is necessary to live a good life. Next, I will define what Socrates views justice to be. Then, I will iterate over Socrates' reasons for obeying the state. Following this, I will culminate these definitions into the argument Socrates makes as to why it would be wrong to break his tacit agreement with the state of Athens by escaping his cell. Finally, I will end by explaining why Crito fails to construct a convincing objection, and I will go in-depth into my own objection to Socrates and how Socrates may have responded to it.

Socrates stresses the importance of living a good life and defines what is necessary to do so. His parameters are straightforward: The wellness of the body and the wellness of the soul, with the wellness of the soul placed in higher importance above the body. Socrates does this by rejecting Crito's claim that the majority opinion should be valued by arguing that good opinions should be valued over bad opinions, and only the wise minority have good opinions (Crito 44c). He then goes on to stress that if we ruin our bodies by following bad advice, such as advice from the unwise majority, then life is not worth living (47d). For example, rather than taking advice

from the majority of people on how to heal from disease, instead take advice only from a doctor who is wise in that subject. Socrates goes on to prove that in the same vein as the body, we should not ruin our soul by following bad advice, as that too would make life not worth living (47e). Socrates ends this round of deliberation by comparing the soul to the body. He introduces the question of whether it is better to preserve the body by destroying the soul or to preserve the soul by destroying the body (48a). Socrates' current situation is an example of this hierarchy: If he escapes, he preserves his body by not being executed but destroys his soul by breaking an agreement; If he stays, then he preserves his soul at the cost of the destruction of his body. To sum this up, Socrates states "the most important thing isn't living, but living well" (48b).

There are two main parts in Socrates' definition of justice. The first part is that wronging or harming another person is always unjust, even if they have wronged or harmed you (49c). Essentially, there is never a situation where acting unjustly is acting to achieve the good, and therefore one should never act unjustly. Furthermore, Socrates stresses that there is no difference between doing wrong and doing injustice (49c). The second part of Socrates' definition is that the just action is to always fulfill agreements and never break promises, provided they are just (49e). This provision is a crucial part of Socrates' next argument for his tacit agreement with the state of Athens.

Finally, Socrates gives his reasons for how he has entered into an agreement with the state of Athens in the first place. His first reason is that the state created the conditions for your very existence. Through the state, your ancestors were wed and conceived until you were born, and the state provided them with livelihoods and facilities to do so (50d). Furthermore, you were raised and educated by the state and its culture (50d). The person you are is a product of the state. Socrates' third and most important reason is to prove that his agreement with the state is

just (52a). Obedience to the state is conditional on the fact that the state is just. To be just, the state must allow for free and unimpeded exit from the state, and the state must provide the private individual ample opportunity to persuade the state that it is acting unjustly. Insofar as the state meets these requirements, there is no equality between the private individual and the state, and the private individual has no right of retaliation against it (50e).

Based on these conclusions about how to live a good life, what justice is, and the relation between the private individual and the state, Socrates arrives at the conclusion that he should not escape the prison cell. Socrates focuses his argument on the specific situation of whether it is right or wrong for Socrates to escape and avoid execution. In his dialogue with Crito, Socrates provides the following argument as to why he should not leave the cell:

1. For an individual to enter into an agreement with a state, the state must be just.
2. A just state allows for an individual to freely exit it and gives opportunity for an individual to persuade the state if the individual believes the state to be acting unjustly.
3. Socrates was presented by the state of Athens with options to freely leave the state, as well as a trial to persuade the state.
4. Socrates entered a tacit agreement with the state of Athens to follow its laws or face repercussions.
5. Socrates was deemed to not be following laws, and must face repercussions.
6. To avoid aforementioned repercussions would be to break the agreement and harm the state.
7. Breaking agreements and doing harm are always unjust.
8. Unjust actions destroy the soul.

9. Life is not worth living with a destroyed soul.

C. Socrates should not escape the cell

This argument presented by Socrates is valid: If a state S meets conditions K then an agreement A is entered ($S \wedge K \rightarrow A$). If A, then laws L must be followed for one to be acting justly J ($A \wedge L \rightarrow J$). If J, then one preserves one's soul O ($J \rightarrow O$). If O, then one lives a good life G and life is worth living ($O \rightarrow G$). However, if laws L are not followed in agreement A then one is not acting justly J and not preserving the soul O and cannot live a good life G ($\sim L \rightarrow A \wedge \sim L \rightarrow \sim J \rightarrow \sim O \rightarrow \sim G$). Therefore, if one is not following laws L then one cannot live a good life G ($\therefore \sim L \rightarrow \sim G$). The argument is valid, so the effectiveness of the argument is therefore predicated on its soundness, which can be assessed by verifying the definitions that Socrates constructs his argument from. Under Socrates' definitions, the argument is sound. Crito finds little success in challenging Socrates because these definitions are widely accepted for Athenians in that time period, so Crito makes no objections.

Socrates makes critical assumptions in his defense of the state. Unjust laws may continue to exist in a just state by no individual successfully persuading the state that such laws are unjust. To this degree, it seems that Socrates holds individuals to a higher standard than the state. The state is allowed to make mistakes, but private individuals cannot. He puts forth the idea that any injustice one commits will cause irredeemable damage to the soul, even if it is a mistake. For the state, however, no injustice is unjust until an individual can prove it. This seems too strict a system to socially operate under, and the inequality between state and individual is massive. Socrates may respond to my objections that the state unknowingly does unjust things whereas the individual knowingly commits them. The issue with this response is that Socrates' argument rests on the idea that the minority of wise opinions found in the state are to be the most

respected, and thus the state should be the most knowledgeable of any entity within a system. The state then unknowingly committing injustice is a contradiction of this supporting idea.